VERB TENSE

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WHAT IS VERB TENSE?

In English, there are many ways to express time. Words like *early*, *late*, *last week*, *yesterday*, *today*, *tonight*, *tomorrow*, and *next year* help us specifically identify a period of time; in addition to these, **verbs play an important role in communicating the "when" of an idea.**

HOW MANY TENSES ARE THERE?

English verbs have three main tenses (past, present, and future) and four forms of each of these tenses (simple, progressive, perfect, and perfect progressive).

Note the patterns in the following chart for the verb "to learn" as it would appear after "I" in each of the twelve tenses:

	Simple	**Progressive** **Be+ verb+ ing**	**Perfect** have + verb+ed	**Perfect progressive** have+been+ verb+ing
	Verb "to learn" is used here in the first person singular (I)			
Past: **verb+ed**	Learned	Was learning	Had learned	Had been learning
Present **Verb**	Learn	Am learning	Have learned	Have been learning
Future **Will+ verb**	Will learn	Will be learning	Will have learned	Will have been learning

Notes:

1. Verb forms may be constructed differently for irregular verbs (for example, *I dr**i**nk/ I dr**a**nk/ I have dr**u**nk two liters of water*).

2. Specific form of *be* and *have* depends on tense (past or present) and the noun or pronoun it follows (singular/plural, *I, you, he/she/it, we, they*).
3. “Am going to” can be substituted for “will”; it is slightly less formal but otherwise synonymous.

WHEN DO WE USE EACH TENSE?

 Refer to the following explanations to determine which tense is most appropriate in a given situation:

• **SIMPLE PAST**—The action or state of being has been completed.

I learned multiplication when I was seven.

I ran two miles.

• **PAST PROGRESSIVE**—The verb took place over a period of time or was in progress when interrupted.

I was learning French when the foreign language program was discontinued.

I was just fixing dinner.

• **PAST PERFECT**—The verb was completed before another occurrence in the past.

I had already learned ten definitions before Alex arrived for our study session.

My parents had dated only four times when my dad proposed.

• **PAST PERFECT PROGRESSIVE**—A verb that took place over a period of time has been completed.

I had been learning about my ancestors long before genealogy became so popular.

I had been planning a trip to Benin, but I realized I didn’t have money for the airfare.

• **SIMPLE PRESENT**—The verb shows a current action or state of being, expresses a habitual occurrence, general truth, belief, or fact, or communicates about works of literature and other media that remain unchanged through time.

I learn best in the morning.

This 1940s film encourages us to reconsider stereotypes about that decade.

• **PRESENT PROGRESSIVE**—The verb expresses a continuing action (this form is less frequently used for non-action verbs such as *believe, wish,* and *know*).

I am learning more from my mentors than I ever thought possible.

He is obviously trying to get your attention. exceptional

• **PRESENT PERFECT**—The verb began in the past and continues to the present.

I have learned I should never chase squirrel.

Hannah hasn't skipped a class since last year.

• **PRESENT PERFECT PROGRESSIVE**—The verb, which began in the past, continues to the present and possibly the future.

I have been learning English grammar for a lifetime, and I still make mistakes.

Yanni has been living in Gbominan since her mom found work there last year.

• **SIMPLE FUTURE**—The verb expresses a future action or state of being.

I will learn to drive a car with a manual transmission before my next birthday.

The rhododendrons will bloom while I am on vacation.

• **FUTURE PROGRESSIVE**—The verb takes place in the future and continues over a period of time.

I will be learning how to fry fish even after we leave Montana.

Evan will be sipping drinks decorated with little umbrellas.

• **FUTURE PERFECT**—The verb will be completed by a specific future time.

By the time you're able to program this computer, I will have learned how to double-click.

Mother will have had knee surgery by then, so she might be able to join the walking tour.

• **FUTURE PERFECT PROGRESSIVE**—The verb will be ongoing until a specific future time.

When I finish school, I will have been learning German for eight years.

By tomorrow, we will have been traveling for three weeks.

TIPS FOR USING VERB TENSES

 When you can keep a verb tense simple, do. For example, if both of the following sentences make your meaning clear, the first one is the better choice:

I learned to knit before I turned six.

I had been learning to knit before I turned six.

 Avoid unnecessary shifts in tense. The following example switches from present to past to present again, creating confusion for the reader:

I enjoy being in Spain; I played soccer every day and handball every night.

 It is okay to switch from one tense to another as long as there is a specific reason to do so (many of the example sentences above include more than one tense).